The Father

By Florian Zeller (translated by Christopher Hampton)

Suggested Roles: Actor – Andre Actress – Anne, Man, Woman

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

ANDRE: **(Pg 6-7)** I'm telling you. She stole my watch.

ANNE: Isn't it more likely you just lost it?

ANDRE: No, no, no. I set a trap for her. I left my watch somewhere, out in the open, to see if she'd take it.

ANNE: Where? Where did you leave it?

ANDRE: Mm? Somewhere. Can't remember. All I know is it's now nowhere to be found. Nowhere to be found. I can't find it, there's your proof. That girl stole it from me. I know it. So, maybe I called her a . . . Maybe I got a bit annoyed.

ANNE: I don't know what to do, Dad. She doesn't want to work here anymore. This is the third one you've . . .

ANDRE: I don't need her! I don't need her or anyone else! I can manage very well on my own!

ANNE: **(Pg 8)** Dad, you have to understand. I can't leave you on your own. You have to accept the idea that you need someone. *(almost to herself)* Why can't you understand?

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Andre is a man facing persecution from all sides, and he refuses to take it any longer.*
ACTRESS: *First some girl, a "helper" -- whom he doesn't need at all -- steals his favorite watch.*
ACTOR: *Then his daughter Anne tries to take his apartment away –*
ACTRESS: *The beautiful apartment he's had for over thirty years, in which he is still quite capable of living, thank you very much!*
ACTOR: *After all, he still has all his faculties. . . Doesn't he?*
ACTRESS: **According to Columbia University Medical Center 10% of US adults over the age of 65 suffer from dementia.*

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ACTOR: *A number that is expected to more than double by the year 2060.*
ACTRESS: *The Father by Florian Zeller and translated to English by Christopher Hampton presents a sobering and realistic look at the world through the eyes of a man experiencing dementia.*

ANDRE: **(Pg 11-13)** *(alone)* I've got to find that lawyer's number. I haven't lived all these years to be treated like this. No. I've got to phone . . . Yes. A lawyer. My own daughter . . . My own daughter . . . *(a man suddenly appears)*

MAN: Everything all right?

ANDRE: What are you doing in my apartment?

MAN: Andre, don't you recognize me? It's Pierre . . . I live here.

ANDRE: You live in my apartment? What is this nonsense.

MAN: I'm going to phone Anne. *(he moves towards the phone)* Your daughter . . .

ANDRE: Thank you. I know who Anne is! You a friend of hers? *(no answer)* I'm speaking to you. Do you know Anne?

MAN: I'm her husband . . . **(Pg 14)** *(Andre tries to remember the name)* Pierre.

ANDREW: **(Pg 12)** *(caught off-guard)* You are?

MAN: Yes, coming up on ten years *(he dials a number)*

ANDRE: *(trying to cover his confusion)* Of course. Yes, yes. **(Pg 14)** That's right, Pierre. **(Pg 12)** Ten years, already? Time passes so fast . . . I thought . . .

MAN: *(on the phone)* Hello, darling. Will you be done soon? Your father isn't feeling very well. I think he'd like to see you. Yes. Don't be too long. *(he hangs up)* She'll be here soon – just out shopping.

ANDRE: She told me she was going to go and live in London.

MAN: I don't think so, Andre.

ANDRE: I'm not an idiot. She told me she's met an Englishman. She was moving to go and live with him. *(suspicious, then he figures it out)* You didn't know anything about the Englishman?

MAN: *(amused)* No.

ANDRE: Oops-a-daisy! *(he comforts Pierre)* Chin up. They all end up leaving sooner or later. I

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speak from experience. *(brief pause)* **(Pg 14-15)** . . . What was I going to say? Oh, yes, your wife! She's cooking up something against me. I suspect she wants to put me in a home for . . . Yes, she does. For . . . *(he pulls a face representing an old man)* But let me make something absolutely clear: I'm not leaving my apartment! I'm not leaving it!

MAN: This isn't your apartment, Andre. You moved here, to our place while . . .

ANDRE: *(laughs and rolls his eyes, the turns away)* Now I've heard everything!

ANNE: Are you all right, Dad? . . . Dad? *(he turns back, but doesn't recognize her)*

ANDRE: What is this nonsense? **(Pg 16-17)** Where's Anne?

ANNE: I'm here, Dad. *(she realizes he doesn't recognize her)* I went to do some shopping and now I'm back. Is everything's all right.

ANDRE: *(annoyed)* I was just standing there. Standing quietly in the living room looking for a telephone number and suddenly your husband arrived and . . .

ANNE: Dad, I'm not married. I got divorced more than five years ago. Have you forgotten.

ANDRE: What? Well, then who's he?

ANNE: Who?

ANDRE: Are you doing this on purpose? Him! Who just left with the chicken. *(clearly, she doesn't know what he's talking about)* The chicken! A minute ago, you were holding a chicken, were you not? A chicken. A CHICKEN! All this nonsense is driving me crazy.

ANNE: **(Pg 18-19)** Now don't worry. Everything'll sort itself out. Mm? *(tenderly)* Don't worry. Have you taken your pills?

ANDRE: What's that got to do with anything? There was this man claiming this wasn't my apartment. He told me . . .

ANNE: Let's give you your pills. The evening dose. Then you'll feel better.

ANDRE: This is my apartment, isn't it? Anne . . . This really is my apartment, isn't it? *(he turns away, and when he turns back, Anne has become an unknown man)*

MAN: **(Pg 47-48)** Can I ask you a question? *(the man moves closer, there's something threatening about his approach)* I want an honest answer . . . can you do that for me? *(Andre is caught off-guard and is clearly intimidated and frightened)* How much longer

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do you intend to go on ruining your daughter's life? *(he slaps Andre)*

ANDRE: What are you doing? I can't allow this.

MAN: You can't allow it? *(he smiles and slaps Andre again)*

ANDRE: Stop it! Do you hear me? Stop this at once! *(Andre crouches and covers his face, in a humiliating defensive position and the MAN morphs back into ANNE)*

ANNE: **(Pg 49-50)** Dad . . . Dad . . . *(she gently pulls his hands from his face)* What's the matter? Look at me. Are you all right? What is it? What's the matter *(Andre begins to sob, Anne holds him in her arms and strokes his hair)*

ANDRE: What time is it?

ANNE: It's eight o'clock. Time to eat.

ANDRE: Eight o'clock in the evening? But I thought it was morning. I've only just got up. Look, I'm still in my pyjamas. *(he seems very lost)* **(Pg 54-55)** I have to get dressed. Where are my clothes?

ANNE: Dad. You can get dressed later. There's nothing to worry about.

ANDRE: I'm in my pyjamas. I have to put my pants on *(he shuffles off stage then wanders back in, confused)*

******* Scene change******

A white bed, reminiscent of a hospital bed. Andre doesn't know where he is. A woman wearing a white coat comes in.

ANDRE: **(Pg 58-59)** Who put this bed here? In the middle of the living room? Anne! This is really getting out of hand.

WOMAN: Don't get upset.

ANDRE: I'm not upset. You just don't put a bed in the middle of a living room. It doesn't make any sense at all. Where's Anne?

WOMAN: Look, I've brought you your medication.

ANDRE: What are you, a nurse? *(finally realizing who he's talking to)* Oh, you are. . . I see. You're a nurse. What are you doing here?

WOMAN: Looking after you.

ANDRE: Amazing! Nobody tells me anything in this house. I really need a little word with

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Anne. What time is it?

WOMAN: Time for your medication.

ANDRE: Yes, all right, fine. Let's take the medication *(makes a big show of it, then notices his watch isn't on his wrist)* I've lost my watch! **(Pg 6)** That girl stole it from me. I know it! **(Pg 59)** Anne? Anne!?

WOMAN: Your daughter isn't here, Andre . . . remember, your daughter lives in London . . . **(Pg 60)** But she comes to see you sometimes.

ANDRE: What is this nonsense? *(very confused)* **(Pg 61-62)** Sorry to ask this, but my mind's gone blank . . . I mean, you . . . You . . . Who are you exactly?

WOMAN: I'm Martine.

ANDRE: Martine. That's right. Yes, yes, yes. Martine. Right. Right. And . . . What about me?

WOMAN: What about you?

ANDRE: Me . . . Who exactly am I?

WOMAN: You? You're Andre.

ANDRE: Andre?

WOMAN: Yes.

ANDRE: Are you sure?

WOMAN: *(amused)* Yes.

ANDRE: Andre? Nice name, Andre . . . Don't you think?

WOMAN: It's a very nice name.

ANDRE: My mother gave it to me, I imagine. Did you know her? My mother?

WOMAN: No.

ANDRE: She was so . . . she had very big eyes. It was . . . I can see her face now. I hope she'll come and see me sometimes. Mommy. Do you think she might come occasionally for the weekend . . .

WOMAN: Your daughter?

ANDRE: *(he's crushed by sudden grief)* No, mommy. I . . . I want out of here. Someone come and get me! I want to go back home. *(he sobs)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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****Introduction Source Information***
https://www.cuimc.columbia.edu/news/one-10-older-americans-has-dementia

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